



He returned the favour by clinching the second game at 15 and raced away with the decider at 12. During these 49 minutes of the 75-minute clash, Lakshya was dominant. He showed no hurry to construct the points, used his energy effectively and progressively finished the rallies at the first available opportunity.

His percentage of errors dropped and Chou looked resigned in the second half of the decider. Lakshya sealed a place in the semifinals and needed at least one more win to ensure a medal.

The encounter against Axelsen was never going to be easy. The second-seeded reigning champion, who did not drop a game in the competition, found Lakshya too hot to handle in the first game.

Axelsen, who invited Lakshya to train with him in Dubai more than once, struggled to match the young Indian at the net. Some desperate shots from Axelsen did not help his cause. Lakshya grew in confidence to

enlarge his lead to 15-9 before the Dane closed the gap to 17-18. Lakshya held his nerves to hold three game points at 20-17 but couldn't find the finishing touch. Five straight points and Axelsen was a game ahead.

In the second, Lakshya jumped to 7-0 in quick time but once more, Axelsen was not to be denied a game. He caught up at 10-10 and moved ahead at 13-12 and allowed the struggling Indian just two more points of the last 10.

Once the lanky Dane began dictating terms, Lakshya looked completely out of ideas. The meltdown was dramatic but given the class of Axelsen, the youngster could be excused.

However, the way Lakshya let Lee Zii Jia snatch the bronze from his grasp was hard to explain. A dominating first game saw Lakshya close the opener at 13 in just 20 minutes. A lead of 8-3 in the second was almost like the beginning of the

There's always a next time: The early exit of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty from the men's doubles competition was the biggest shocker. PTI

end for the Malaysian who appeared to have been struggling to even settle down.

No doubt, the drift in the playing hall played its part but then, it was equal for both players. In the second game, when Lakshya played with the drift, he found it increasingly difficult to control the shuttle and often hit long. The loss of this game at 16 meant the momentum shifted to Lee. In quick time, he jumped to 9-2 and stayed comfortably ahead for the duration of the decider which went on for 26 minutes, the same as the second game.

Surprisingly, Lakshya's judgement faltered with alarming consistency. He failed to read the length of Lee's returns when the Malaysian was hitting with the drift. When the players changed sides after the mid-game break, Lakshya began missing the lines. This meltdown, in two successive matches – probably the biggest of Lakshya's young career – made Prakash call a spade a spade when talking to the media.

Prannoy did just what was expected of him and no more. He defeated two lesser-ranked players in the group stage of the competition. Looking unfit in the key clash against Lakshya, he surrendered rather tamely.

Overall, Indian supporters were left praising Lakshya's fourth-place finish. The exit of Satwik and Chirag proved to be the biggest shocker. The elimination of Sindhu, Prannoy and the women's doubles pair was in keeping with their form, rather the lack of it.

It is time for Indian badminton to see beyond the gloss provided by Saina and Sindhu for long. The rise of Satwik and Chirag, coupled with the unpredictable showings of Lakshya, hold some promise for the 2028 Los Angeles Games.

Truly, it is futile to look too far ahead at this point.